



2026 CYBER SECURITY CAREER GUIDE

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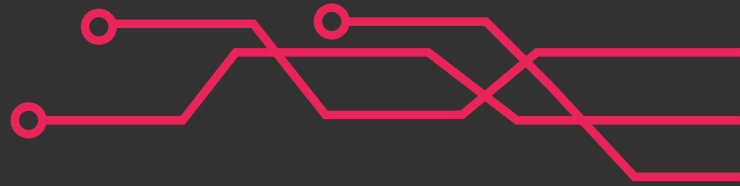
INTRODUCTION

Cybersecurity is a competitive field, and those looking for entry-level positions may be shocked to find those “entry-level” positions asking for years of experience with specific operating systems, tools, and methodologies. But don’t despair, despite the competition, those who can persevere and break into the field are rewarded with fulfilling work, higher salaries, and an ever-changing threat landscape.

Breaking into cybersecurity is not easy. In this guide, we go through the process from start to finish. From choosing your path, to crafting the perfect resume and cover letter, to acing the interview, and more, we share our best advice for securing a role in this field.

A note before we dive in- remember that this advice is generalized for a variety of roles and that there’s no “one way” to break into the industry. Work hard, learn all you can, connect with others, and you’ll find your place in the industry.





CHOOSING YOUR CYBERSECURITY PATH

The first thing to do is to figure out your path. The cybersecurity industry is vast and constantly changing, and there's no way to possibly learn everything.

Below we will lay out three of the most common tracks. If you aren't sure what to pursue, we recommend trying out some free or low-cost training materials to see what peaks your interest.

This field requires a constant commitment to learning, so make sure you are really interested in the material before committing real financial resources and time into studying.





1) DEFENSIVE SECURITY

If your interests lie in defending systems from hackers and cybercriminals, the blue team may be the way to go.

Blue team jobs outnumber offensive and GRC roles and offer more entry points into the industry. It's not uncommon for people to start off in lower level defensive role (like a SOC or cybersecurity analyst) and then switch into a more advanced red team role.

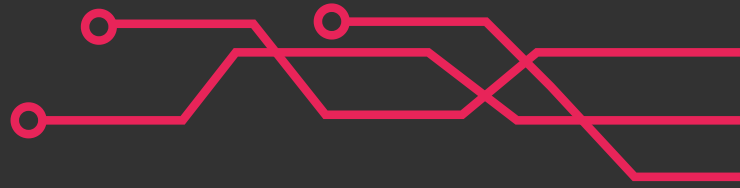
Some common defensive security roles include:

- SOC Analyst/Manager
- Security Engineer
- Threat Hunter
- DFIR Analyst

Salary: Entry-level roles start from \$60-\$90K, Experienced professionals can earn up to \$190K depending on your location and skill set.

Skills: A strong defensive security professional blends technical know-how with analytical thinking, is calm under pressure, and has solid communication skills.





2) OFFENSIVE SECURITY

On the flip side, the red team is composed of individuals who attempt to ethically hack into systems to test those defenses. There are not many “entry” level roles in this segment, as individuals need to have a vast knowledge of systems, software, and tools in order to be successful.

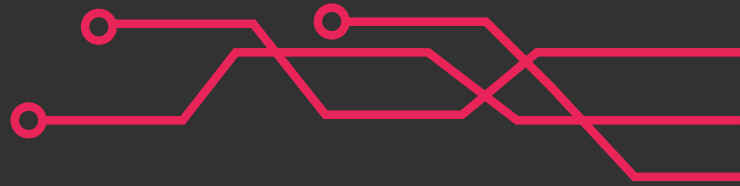
Some common offensive security job titles and roles include:

- Penetration Tester
- Ethical Hacker
- Offensive Security Engineer

Salary: Starts at \$75-100K, more experienced professionals can earn up to \$200K annually.

Skills: An offensive security professional excels at exploiting vulnerabilities, evading detection with stealth and creativity, and clearly communicating technical findings to drive real-world security improvements.





3) GOVERNANCE, RISK, AND COMPLIANCE (GRC)

Not all of the cybersecurity industry is technical. Security policy is the foundation of any security program and we need people to evaluate risk and craft sensible policy.

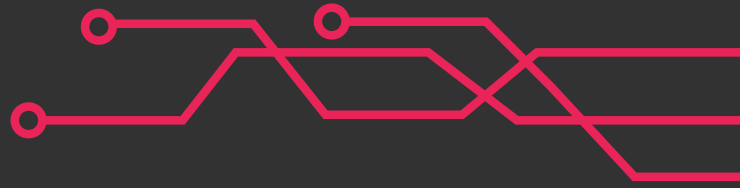
Some common GRC roles include:

- GRC Analyst
- Compliance Analyst
- Information Security Auditor
- GRC Manager

Salary: Entry level roles typically earn between \$90-110K, while more experienced professionals can earn \$140-\$180K annually.

Skills: GRC analysts combine knowledge of cybersecurity frameworks, risk assessment, and regulatory compliance with strong analytical, documentation, and communication skills to help organizations manage security policies and reduce risk.





COLLEGE DEGREES VS CERTIFICATIONS

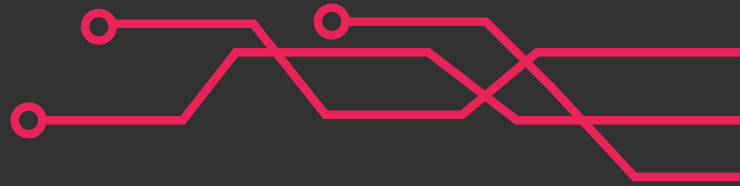
So, you've picked your path- what do you need on your resume to prove your knowledge? There's no one answer or path that will apply to every individual. Our best advice is to identify your target job role, review some job listings, and pick out some common themes that emerge and work to meet those criteria.

For example, if your goal is to be a penetration tester, do a search for active job listings in your area and compare them. Ask yourself the following questions:

- Is a college degree listed? If so, which degrees are preferred?
- Are there any certifications that keep coming up?
- What tools and skills are listed as required to know?

Once you have this information, you can create a study plan to start working on building the skills you'll need to succeed.





COLLEGE DEGREES

Generally speaking you don't "need" a college degree to learn the skills you need to succeed on a job. However, a college degree is often a checkbox and if you don't have one, it can prevent your resume from getting past the ATS or Human Resources department.

Cybersecurity degrees are newer and it's not necessary to have a cybersecurity degree to get a cybersecurity job. Other degrees like software engineering and computer science will help you develop relevant skills for a cybersecurity career.





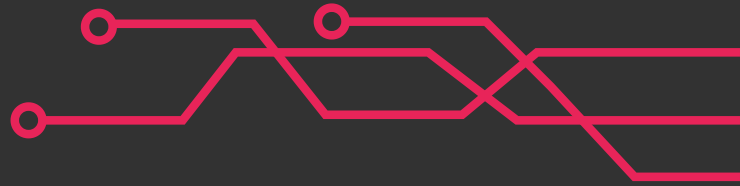
CERTIFICATIONS

Certifications are somewhat similar. No one certification is guaranteed to get you a cybersecurity job, but they can be useful in getting past HR filters and proving you have skills even without job experience.

To find out what certifications will be the most useful for achieving your dream role, review the advice above. When in doubt, it's always better to pursue a practical certification vs a multiple-choice exam. Multiple choice certifications will meet some HR requirements, but they don't demonstrate your ability to perform the job as well as other more practical certifications.

One final tip about certifications- you don't need every certification under the sun to apply to entry-level roles. Start with one or two certifications that meet your criteria and start applying to jobs! Once you've actually snagged a job, many companies will pay for additional training and certifications to help you reach the next level. As you will find out, certifications can get expensive, and you shouldn't let a piece of paper hold you back from applying to roles you otherwise have the skills for.





HOW TO FIND CYBERSECURITY JOBS

Once you've decided on your path and built your skills, it's time to find jobs to apply to. There are a few different approaches to take- including job boards, social media, networking, and recruiters.

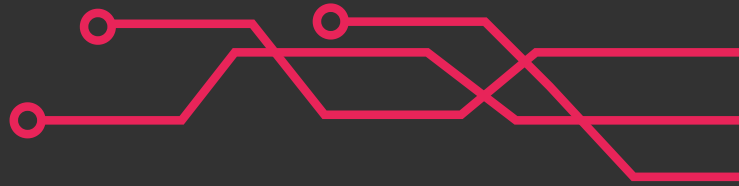
JOB BOARDS

Of course, you will see and apply to jobs listed on traditional job boards like Indeed and ZipRecruiter. But there are also cybersecurity-focused job boards that you should pay attention to. Some of the most popular ones include:

- [CyberSecJobs](#)
- [ClearedJobs](#) – for government/DoD cleared roles
- [Cybersecurity Jobs](#)
- [Dice](#)

Jobs posted on more niche sites may receive fewer applications than those posted on general sites like Indeed, so it increases your chances of getting through the first round.





SOCIAL MEDIA WEBSITES

If you don't already have a LinkedIn account, you should create one and make sure it represents you professionally. We will cover LinkedIn and networking in detail later if you need some help getting started. LinkedIn can be a great place to find jobs, connect with recruiters, and show off your accomplishments.

Discord is another platform where networking and participation can lead to career opportunities. There are specific Discord servers dedicated to job hunting like [Cyber Jobs Hunting](#).

On our [server](#), we regularly see individuals post open positions from their companies. By participating and making connections on Discord, you can get a leg up on the hiring process and get referrals for open positions.

IN-PERSON EVENTS

Attending in-person meetups and conferences can also lead to jobs. From participating in local B-Sides groups, to attending larger conferences like DEF CON, connecting with others in the industry is a great way to find job opportunities.

We will have more to say about social media and in-person networking later on!





WORKING WITH RECRUITERS

To close, let's talk a little bit about recruiters. There are a lot of shady recruiters out there who have created some confusion for those new to job hunting. Recruiters typically work in-house or are hired by companies to find candidates for open positions. They are paid by the company who hired them- **they should never ask you for payment and you don't need to hire a recruiter to find you a job.**

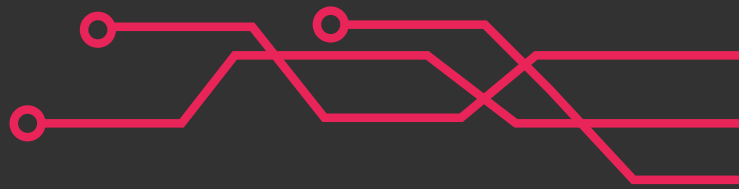
If a recruiter reaches out to you with an opportunity that sounds interesting, hear them out! If the job sounds interesting and you want to apply, you may need to go through a slightly different application process so that the recruiter gets credit for finding you.

A good recruiter is there to help you through the process. That may mean additional preparation calls before phone screens and interviews with the hiring manager.

Remember the incentives- if you get hired, the recruiter gets paid. Keep that in mind and you'll be just fine! If a recruiter is giving you bad vibes or wants you to do unethical things, tell the hiring team.

Some recruiters may want to connect with you on social media sites even if they don't currently have a role that is a good fit. It's not a bad idea to connect with a recruiter- you never know when they'll have a role available that you're interested in!





CREATING A RESUME

Once you've acquired the skills and knowledge, it's time to start putting together your resume. First, let's look at the core components of a resume.

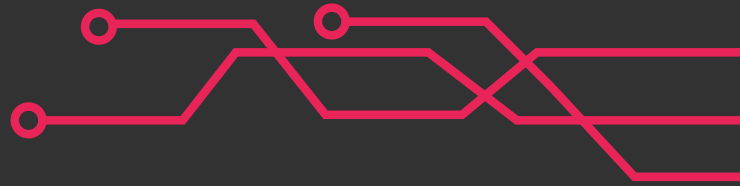
A strong cybersecurity resume is structured to highlight your technical expertise, certifications, and practical experience in securing systems, networks, and data.

Here's a breakdown of the essential parts:

- Header
- Objective/Summary
- Experience
- Education
- Certifications
- Skills
- Tools
- Projects
- Publications/Talks
- Active security clearances

Use our [template](#) to get started!





HEADER

The header is a minor, but essential part of the resume. It's where you include contact information and links to your GitHub or portfolio.

FIRST MIDDLE LAST

address • number • email

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY / OBJECTIVE

(OPTIONAL BUT RECOMMENDED)

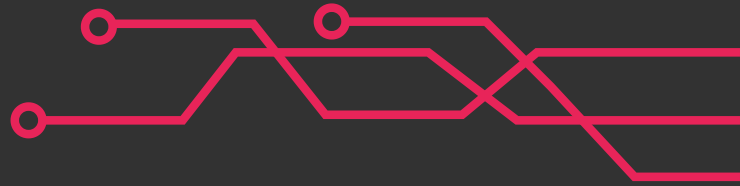
The professional summary is a brief (2–3 sentence) overview of your experience, key skills, and what you're looking for. It's optional, but highly recommended because it gives you an opportunity to inject more personalization and personality into your resume. When writing a professional summary, make sure it is tailored to the role. It should tell a story about who you are, where you've been and where you are looking to go with your career.

OBJECTIVE

Cybersecurity professional with a strong interest in ethical hacking, penetration testing, vulnerability analysis, and network security. Hard-working, energetic, personable, and technical-minded individual. Currently in a cybersecurity role where I continue to develop and learn new abilities while contributing to the overall success of the organization. I also possess:

- Experience in scripting languages including Python and Bash.
- Excellent task management. Ability to handle multiple projects simultaneously.
- Experience with security toolkits such as Kali Linux, Metasploit, and Burp Suite Pro.
- Proficient in translating information from technical to executive/management terminology.





The order of the next few sections of your resume will depend on where you are at in your career. If you are just finishing college and don't have much professional experience, you may want to lead with your degree and college projects.

Start with your strongest credentials first and remember that not everything you've ever done needs to go on the resume. A resume is a marketing document that is tailored to each job you are applying for. Don't lie about skills or accomplishments you don't have, but not every job you've ever had needs to be on there if it doesn't strengthen your candidacy.

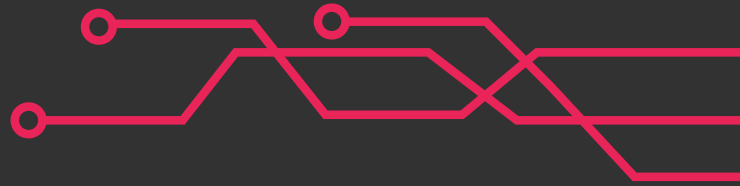
PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

This section highlights what you have achieved in previous positions. You can include internships in this section, but other unpaid volunteer work does not belong here.

For each job you should include:

- Job Title
- Company Name and Location
- Dates of Employment
- Key Responsibilities & Achievements





The key responsibilities and achievement sections of each position should be formatted in a particular way that can sometimes be confusing if you are putting together a resume for the first time. Here's an example of what you would write for a previous job:

EXPERIENCE	Work 1, Remote/Charlotte, NC Founder & CEO	June 2019 to Present
	• Engage in a variety of penetration testing assessments including network (internal and external), web application, wireless, red and purple team, physical, social engineering, and more. • Instructor at TCM Security Academy which provides cybersecurity and ethical hacking training to over 200,000 students.	
	Work 2, Remote/Charlotte, NC Senior Penetration Tester II	March 2018 to June 2019
	• Perform external, internal, physical, wireless, web, SOC, and malware assessments on Fortune 500 companies. • Utilize platforms and tools such as Kali Linux, Metasploit Framework, Burp Suite Pro, and Cobalt Strike. • Interact with clients on high and technical levels to discuss findings and resolutions. • Involved in internal team tool and script development, utilizing Bash and Python, and recently developed a tool that has led to several breaches on external assessments.	

You'll notice a few things about the key responsibilities section. First, each responsibility is listed under a distinct bullet point and every one starts with an action verb. You don't want to use pronouns like "I investigated security events," because it makes the resume unwieldy and hard to follow.





It's also important to quantify your impact as much as possible. Backing up your experiences with data to support the statement is more impactful and demonstrates your ability to thrive. The last thing to note is that this section does not need to fully capture everything you did in this role. You only have 1-2 pages total for your resume, so try to align the key responsibilities with the job you are applying for and what you'll be expected to do.

EDUCATION

How much emphasis to put on this section depends on where you are in your career. If you are a recent graduate you will want to highlight this more compared to someone who already has work experience. At a minimum, you want to list any degrees you have earned and the institution.

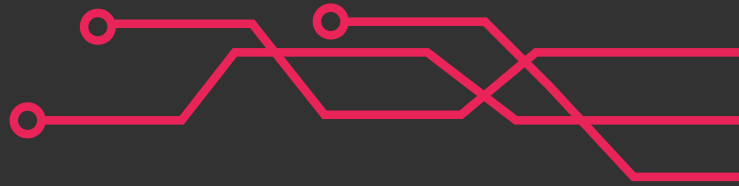
EDUCATION

College – MBA, Computer Information Systems, 3.76 GPA

College – Bachelor's, Accounting (Honors), 3.52 GPA

For more recent graduates, it may make sense to include information about projects completed, GPA, and any awards or honors you received. In most cases, it does not make sense to include information about high school, unless you are immediately entering the workforce after graduation. Then the same applies, include the degree, school, and graduation date on your resume.





CERTIFICATIONS

List relevant certifications with full names and dates (or "In Progress" if applicable). If possible, align the list with the job description and their listed preferences.

Note that a course completion certificate is different from a certification. Completing an online course does not belong on a resume unless there was a test component where you were challenged to prove your skills. This also goes for platforms like TryHackMe and Hack the Box. Earning a "top 1%" badge does not mean much to a cybersecurity hiring manager and is better placed in an additional projects section (if it appears at all).

CERTIFICATIONS

- ISC2 Certified Information Systems Security Professional (CISSP)
- GIAC Systems and Network Auditor (GSNA)
- Practical Network Penetration Tester (PNPT)
- Offensive Security Certified Professional (OSCP) and Wireless Professional (OSWP)
- eLearnSecurity Penetration Tester eXtreme (eCPTX)
- eLearnSecurity Web Application Penetration Tester (eWPT)
- CompTIA A +, Network +, Security +, Linux +, Pentest+





SKILLS & TOOLS

It's often worthwhile to include a bullet list of skills and proficiencies with tools to ensure any applicant tracking systems that scan your resume pick up on those keywords. Once again, this list should be tailored to the job description- if it calls for experience with Burp Suite and you've used the tool for the past three years, you want to make sure it's on your resume. Don't lie and include tools you haven't used before. You may be asked about them in an interview and it will become obvious very quickly.

PROJECTS

Projects are an excellent way to demonstrate experience and drive when you don't have on the job experience. For example, Active Directory is an identity-management tool often used in corporate environments. You might think it's impossible to apply for a job that calls for AD experience if you've never worked in a corporate setting. However, you'd be wrong! By setting up your own home lab with Active Directory, you can familiarize yourself with the UI, learn about how it works, and gain real experience that you can put on a resume.

PROJECTS

TCM Security Academy (<https://academy.tcm-sec.com>)

December 2019 to Present

- Instructor of five best-selling ethical hacking classes that have a combined 400,000 students and 4.8/5.0 rating on the platform

The Cyber Mentor (<https://www.thecybermentor.com/>)

March 2018 to Present

- Actively post cybersecurity training videos on YouTube to over 300,000 subscribers (<https://www.youtube.com/c/thecybermentor>) and stream ethical hacking lessons on Twitch to 25,000 subscribers (<https://www.twitch.tv/thecybermentor>).





It's a cliché to say that the cybersecurity field is always evolving, but it's cliché because it's true. Pursuing projects and professional development on your own time demonstrates your passion and commitment to the field.

ADDITIONAL SECTIONS

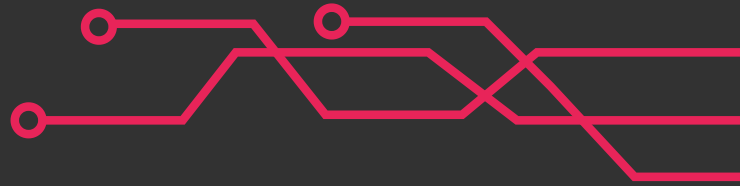
This information is optional to include, but if you have any of the following, you should consider putting it on your resume:

- Security Clearance: Include type and level if active or expired.
- Publications or Blogs: Include links to pieces you've written. It doesn't matter if it's only a personal Medium blog or GitHub that no one reads!
- Conferences / Talks / Workshops: Highlight any public speaking experience.
- Languages: Foreign languages, if relevant, for international roles.

CONCLUSION

Putting together a resume can be a daunting task. We recommend putting together a master file of all your jobs, experience, and education so that it is easier to cut and paste to tailor to specific listings. Customizing the resume for the job you are applying to is the most important thing you can do to maximize your chances of landing a role.





WRITING A COMPELLING COVER LETTER

Even if a cover letter is “optional,” not submitting one could hurt your candidacy. Many people are resistant to writing a cover letter because they don’t understand the purpose. A cover letter is a chance to tell your story and explain how the role you are applying for fits into your path. A good cover letter can move an otherwise “average” application to the top of the list.

As you might expect, this means that a one-size-fits-all cover letter won’t do. A successful cover letter is customized for each company and role you apply to. It doesn’t just repeat the facts on your resume- it brings those facts to life and illustrates the person behind the paper and the passion you have for the industry.

Though every cover letter will be different, let’s take a look at the general structure and some of the basics that every cover letter should include. Generally speaking, you are shooting for 3-5 paragraphs. The cover letter should never be more than one page.





STRUCTURE OF A CUSTOMIZED COVER LETTER (WITH EXAMPLES)

1. HOOK WITH PURPOSE AND RELEVANCE

Your opening paragraph should:

- Mention the job you are applying to and where you found it
- Briefly connect your background to their mission or industry
- Show genuine interest in what they do

Generic:

"I'm applying for the Cybersecurity Analyst position at Acme Corp."

Customized:

"I'm excited to apply for the Cybersecurity Analyst role at Acme Corp. As a longtime follower of your work in securing cloud-native environments and zero-trust architecture, I'm drawn to your innovative approach to enterprise defense and I'm eager to contribute to that mission."





2. CONNECT YOUR SKILLS TO THEIR STACK OR NEEDS

In the body of your letter, get specific on how your experience matches their specific environment, based on the information found in the job description.

Example:

“At my current role, I use Splunk to investigate real-time alerts in a hybrid cloud environment- an experience I understand aligns closely with Acme’s recent shift to Azure-based infrastructure. I also helped develop custom playbooks for incident response in compliance with NIST 800-61, which I know is central to your internal policies based on your recent SOC 2 audit preparation.”

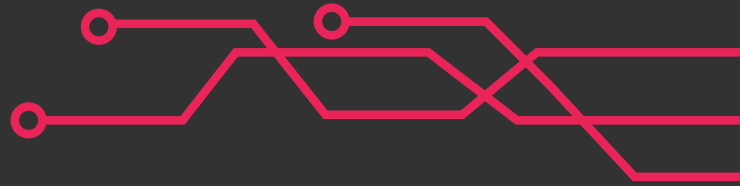
3. SHOW CULTURE FIT OR MISSION ALIGNMENT

Companies want cybersecurity professionals who understand their values, not just their vulnerabilities.

Example:

“I admire Acme’s commitment to open-source security research and collaboration with the MITRE ATT&CK framework. I recently contributed to an open-source EDR enhancement project and published a blog post breaking down TTPs using MITRE mapping, which received recognition in the infosec community.”





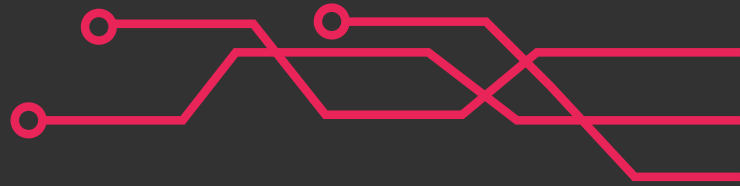
4. FINISH WITH CONFIDENCE AND A CALL TO ACTION

End strong and make it clear you're ready to contribute to their specific mission.

Example:

"I'm enthusiastic about the opportunity to support Acme Corp in proactively defending critical infrastructure and driving innovation in the security space. I would welcome the chance to speak further about how my background and curiosity-driven mindset can serve your team."





HOW TO CUSTOMIZE A COVER LETTER

You may be thinking how can I possibly know what the company is looking for? As a security professional, basic OSINT will be your best friend.

First, go straight to the source- the job description. What language are they using? What tools and skills are mentioned? Use them in your cover letter to show your alignment with the role.

Then, put those OSINT skills to work and check out their website, LinkedIn, blog, and press releases. What are they proud of? What initiatives have they been highlighting? Showcase your knowledge of the company and connect it to your goals.

Finally, align your resume with their values to demonstrate how you are a culture fit. Don't fake it. If you're not genuinely interested, it shows.





ACE THE INTERVIEW

Finally, you've got an invitation for an interview! If that excitement is followed by panic, fear not. If you take the time to prepare for your interview, you can be confident and ready for any questions that come your way. Read on for our tips for acing your cybersecurity job interview.

A NOTE ON PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

Before you even schedule the first interview, note that your communication during the process will factor into your evaluation.

Be polite and communicate professionally with everyone you interact with throughout this process. That includes assistants, coordinators, and HR personnel. Treat everyone with respect and dignity and understand that how you act in these instances makes an impression that can either positively or negatively impact your candidacy.





TYPES OF INTERVIEWS

The interview process varies from company to company, so take our explanations here with a grain of salt. This is an example of a typical interview process, but is by no means the only way a hiring process works.

Before we dive into it, remember that an interview is also for you to learn about the company and if you would like to work there. Be on the lookout for red flags and ask questions to help determine if it's a good fit for you. Don't let desperation cloud your judgement- it's better to find the right job and not just any job.

PHONE SCREEN/INTERVIEW

Many interview processes kick off with a short phone call (15-30 minutes) with the human resources department. These interviews often focus on confirming some basic information with the candidate, such as basic experience and technical abilities, certifications and schooling, location, and soft skills. Don't make the mistake of not taking this interview seriously. Show up on time, think about the skills and experience you want to highlight, and what excites you about this specific role and company.

If this interview goes well, you'll progress to an interview with the hiring manager- aka your likely boss!





HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW

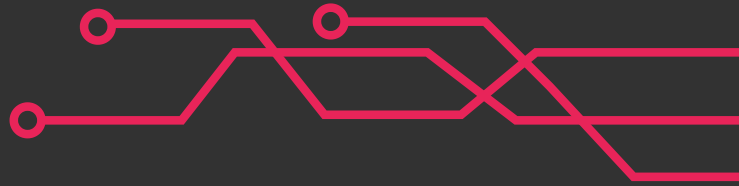
There are a few ways that the next interview stage can go, but typically the hiring manager is part of the next phase. These interviews can take place in person or via virtual conference rooms.

Either way, be sure to show up in professional dress and neatly groomed. Even if you could wear a hoodie on the job, you should look nicer than usual for an interview. This could be as simple as a collared shirt or a zip-up pull-over.

If you are interviewing from a remote location, choose a place that is neat, clean and free of distractions and excessive noise. You should expect to be on camera. Do your best to plan for contingencies and avoid technical mishaps. For example, have a charger on hand, leave time to test your microphone and internet connections, and prepare for the worst.

The hiring manager is someone in the chain of command who will have oversight of your work if you are hired. The interview may also include future colleagues, stakeholders, and usually a member of the human resources team. You can expect this interview to start diving into technical skills, as well as how you handle interpersonal situations. Next, we look into how to prepare for these types of interviews.





STAR METHOD

There are a few ways that interviewers assess technical and behavioral skills. Nevertheless, one of the best tools you can add to your interviewing toolbox is something called the STAR method. STAR is an acronym that stands for:

Situation

Task

Action

Result

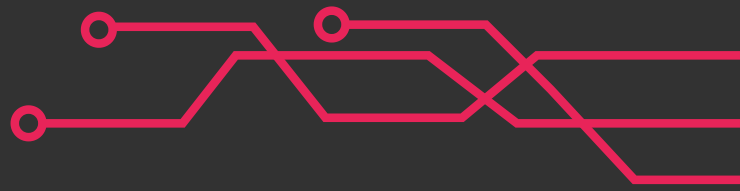
Whenever an interviewer asks you a question like “Tell me about a time you had to respond to two security alerts with similar severity- what did you do?”. Use the STAR method to answer:

SITUATION

First, give more specifics and context for the situation.

For example: *"While working as a Security Operations Center (SOC) Analyst at ABC Financial, I was monitoring the SIEM one morning when two high-severity alerts came in within minutes of each other. One was a potential phishing email reported by a user; the other was an endpoint alert showing suspicious PowerShell activity on a critical server."*





TASK

Then, you can explain your responsibility or the problem you had to solve.

In this scenario, it may be something like "I was responsible for triaging both alerts quickly, determining which posed a more immediate threat, and ensuring proper containment and escalation as needed."

ACTION

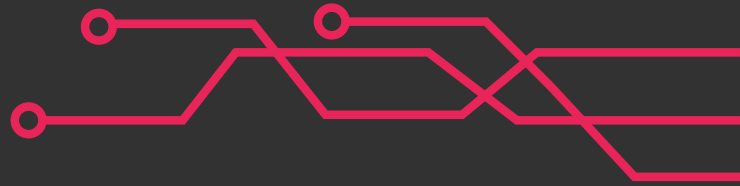
Next, go into detail about the specific steps you took to address the task.

Example:

"I first assessed both alerts using our playbooks and threat intelligence feeds. The PowerShell alert was on a production server that handled sensitive data, and the activity matched known tactics used in fileless malware attacks. The phishing email, while serious, had only been reported by one user and hadn't been clicked yet.

I prioritized the endpoint alert and immediately isolated the affected server from the network, pulled system logs, and began forensic analysis to confirm whether it was part of a larger attack. Meanwhile, I delegated the phishing email to another analyst on shift and provided them with guidance to check if it had spread further and whether anyone else interacted with it.





Once the server was isolated and under investigation, I circled back to review the phishing incident to ensure it was contained and documented."

RESULT

Finally, share the outcome of your actions. Be specific and quantify when possible.

Example:

"By triaging based on impact and asset criticality, we neutralized a real malware threat before it could exfiltrate data, and the phishing attempt turned out to be a generic scam that didn't spread. The quick response minimized downtime and risk. I later proposed an update to our triage SOPs to improve handling multiple concurrent alerts, which was adopted by the team."





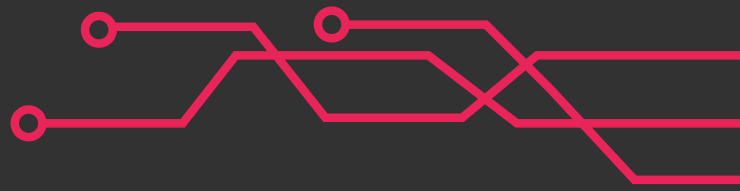
Using this method gives the interviewer insight into how you think and respond to situations, which is exactly what they want to get out of an interview.

Hopefully it's easy to see how these answers are much more comprehensive than a one sentence answer. We also recommend preparing for questions like this in advance.

Head over to your preferred search engine or AI chat bot and ask it to give you examples for interview questions related to the position you are applying to.

Then write down your answers. If you are using an AI chat bot, have it grade your answers and suggest improvements. You can bring these notes to an interview, but don't read directly from them or rely on them too heavily. The process of preparing for the interview will help increase your confidence and give you a well of material to pull from when these questions arise.





TECHNICAL ASSESSMENTS

It's also possible that you will be presented with certain technical challenges to assess your skills. Once again you can query the internet and AI models for likely skills that will be tested depending on the role. The format of these challenges may vary. Sometimes you will be asked to explain a technical concept using slides or a whiteboard. Other times, you may be tasked with a CTF challenge or another type of live assessment.

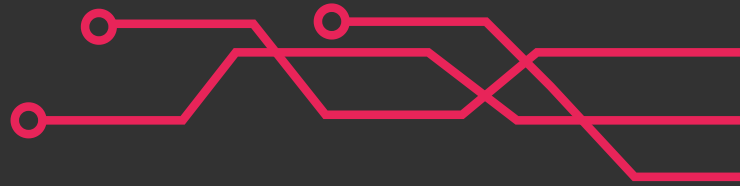
FINAL ADVICE

Interviewers are people too! Connect with them on a personal level and don't forget about soft skills.

Don't lie- if you don't know the answer to a question or aren't familiar with a tool, it's better to be honest and try to highlight a related skill, rather than making things up. The cybersecurity field is so vast, it's impossible to know everything. Highlight your ability to learn and aptitude for picking up new things instead.

Not every interview will work out, but it's a good opportunity to learn, grow, and meet other cybersecurity professionals. The industry is small- a solid, but unsuccessful interview could lead to another opportunity later on.





NETWORKING & PERSONAL BRANDING

And that leads us to our last topic- networking and personal branding. Many people hate networking, but it's one of the best investments you can make in your career.

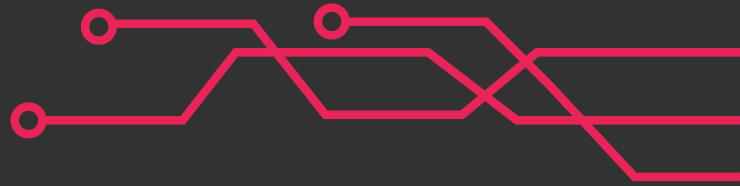
Even before you are ready to apply, start networking and connecting with others! There are more ways than ever before to connect with others in the industry and find job opportunities.

ONLINE NETWORKING

The internet has lowered the barrier to entry and has made it easier than ever for us to make connections. Even if you are more introverted, there are positive contributions you can make online with less stress.

Let's look at a few platforms where you can connect with others and build your personal brand.





LINKEDIN

As we mentioned above, LinkedIn is an excellent place to find jobs and connect with recruiters. If you are just starting out, begin by building out a thoughtful and optimized profile. The most important things to do include:

- Craft an “About” section where you have an elevator pitch or TLDR of who you are.
- Provide an accurate headline for your profile. Even if you are unemployed, you can use this area to broadcast the types of roles you are interested in or qualified to perform.
- Use a professional headshot. It doesn’t have to be taken by a “real” photographer, but should be something that could be seen on an employer’s website.
- Ensure your professional experience is up to date. There is no need to list every job you have ever had, but your last several relevant roles should be included.

Once your profile is established, start building your network. The first thing to do is connect with people you know.

Then start connecting with or at least following other people in the space. It’s a good practice to preface any connection requests with a friendly message introducing yourself (especially since some folks may be wary of accepting due to aggressive cold-calling vendors).





Once your profile is set up, it's time to start posting and interacting with other people's content! If you have some insights you'd like to share, some personal experiences others may be able to relate to, or thoughts on a recent news item, your profile is a perfect forum. This can help you establish rapport with others, and hopefully lead to some conversations.

MEDIUM/GITHUB/WEBSITES/BLOGS

If you don't know what to post on LinkedIn, start creating your own content and publishing on one of these platforms.

Just finished a challenge on Hack the Box? Write up a walkthrough for how you did it and publish it. Are you creating tools or doing projects- write about them!

Communication is an enormous part of a successful cybersecurity career and these writeups demonstrate your ability to explain technical concepts. Don't let imposter syndrome bring you down- if you started your journey last week, there is someone starting today who can learn from your experience.





DISCORD

Joining a few Discord communities focused on cybersecurity is a fantastic way to meet like-minded individuals. Here's a few to check out:

- TCM Security (that's us!)
- BHIS
- CyberInfo
- Hack Smarter

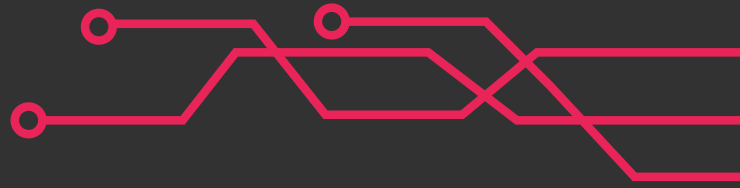
Make sure you follow the rules and guidelines and start participating!

IN-PERSON NETWORKING

In-person events can be overwhelming, but if you start small and local you may have more success. Search your area for local BSides groups and start showing up to their meetups. You'll meet local employers, new friends, and learn a lot along the way.

Larger conferences like DEF CON, Black Hat, Wild West Hacking Fest, and others can also provide valuable networking experience. However, they can be more expensive, so it's maybe not the best option if you are just starting out in the industry.





CONCLUSION

Landing your first job in cybersecurity is one of the toughest parts of the journey. Don't neglect your mental health along the way. There will be rejections and they are not a reflection of all the work you've put in. The job market is very competitive and it will take time to land that initial role. Keep your head up, keep trying, and eventually you will succeed.

